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French literary theory today

A reader

edited by

TZVETAN TODOROV

Maître de Recherche, Centre National de la Recherche Scientifique, Paris

translated by R. Carter

CAMBRIDGE UNIVERSITY PRESS

Cambridge

London New York New Rochelle Melbourne Sydney

EDITIONS DE LA MAISON DES SCIENCES DE
L'HOMME

Paris

016608351

Published by the Press Syndicate of the University of Cambridge
The Pitt Building, Trumpington Street, Cambridge CB2 1RP
32 East 57th Street, New York, NY 10022, USA
296 Beaconsfield Parade, Middle Park, Melbourne 3206, Australia
and Editions de la Maison des Sciences de l'Homme
54 Boulevard Raspail, 75270 Paris Cedex 06

© Maison des Sciences de l'Homme and
Cambridge University Press 1982

First published 1982

Printed in Great Britain at the Pitman Press, Bath

Library of Congress catalogue card number: 81-21656

British Library Cataloguing in Publication Data

Todorov, Tzvetan

French literary theory today

1. Literature—Philosophy 2. Criticism
—France

I. Title II. Carter, R.

801 PN45

ISBN 0 521 23036 5

ISBN 0 521 29777 X Pbk

PN
45
F66
1982
C.2

P.P.

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were always inclined, from Aristotle onward, to set up tradition as a norm and to canonize what exists, than the exploration of the various *possibilities of discourse*, with respect to which works already written and forms already exemplified appear merely as so many particular cases beyond which loom other predictable, or deducible, combinations. This is one of the interpretations which can be given to the celebrated formulas of Roman Jakobson who proposes as the object of literary studies not literature but literarity, not poetry but the poetic function: more generally, the object of theory is to be not just the *real*, but the *virtual* – all that is potentially literary. This opposition between an *open* poetics and the closed poetics of the classical tradition indicates clearly that what is at issue here is not, as might perhaps be thought, a return to the precritical past: literary theory, on the contrary, will be modern, and bound up with the modernity of literature, or will be nothing at all.

When introducing his programme for the teaching of poetics, Valéry declared with a salutary, and, all in all, justified insolence, that the object of this teaching, 'far from being substituted for or opposed to the teaching of literary history, should be to give to the latter simultaneously an introduction, a sense, and a purpose'. The relations between poetics and criticism could be of the same nature, with the difference – capital – that Valéry's poetics expected next to nothing in return from literary history, termed a 'vast fake', while literary theory has much to learn from the specific studies of criticism. While literary history is in no sense a fake, nevertheless it is clearly, like the philological techniques of deciphering and establishing a text (and in reality much more so), an *ancillary* discipline for the study of literature, for it only explores (through biography, the study of sources and influences, of the genesis and the 'career' of literary works, etc.) the secondary aspects. Criticism, on the other hand, is and will remain a fundamental approach, and it can be predicted that the future of literary studies resides essentially in the exchange and the necessary cross-fertilization between criticism and poetics – based on an awareness and exploitation of their *complementarity*.

Part II

2. The reality effect

ROLAND BARTHES

When Flaubert, describing the room occupied by Madame Aubain, Félicité's mistress, tells us that 'on an old piano, under a barometer, there was a pyramid of boxes and cartons',¹ or when Michelet, describing the death of Charlotte Corday and reporting that in prison, before the arrival of the executioner, she was visited by an artist who painted her portrait, gives us the detail that 'after an hour and a half, someone knocked softly at a little door behind her',² these authors, like so many others, produce *notations* (data, descriptive details) which structural analysis, occupied as it is with separating out and systematizing the main articulations of narrative, ordinarily, and up to the present, has left out, either by excluding from its inventory (by simply failing to mention them) all those details which are 'superfluous' (as far as structure is concerned), or else by treating these same details (as the present author has himself attempted to do)³ as fillers, padding (catalyses), assigned indirect functional value in that, cumulatively, they constitute an indication of characterization or atmosphere, and so can finally be salvaged as part of the structure.

It would seem, however, that if we want the analysis to be truly exhaustive (and what would any method be worth which did not account for the whole of its object, in the present case, the entire surface of the narrative fabric), to try to encompass the ultimate detail, the indivisible unit, the fleeting transition, in order to assign these a place in the structure, we will inevitably be confronted with *notations* which no function (not even the most indirect) will allow us to justify: these details are scandalous (from the point of view of structure), or, even more disturbingly, they seem to be allied with a kind of narrative *luxury*, profligate to the extent of throwing up 'useless' details and increasing the cost of narrative information. So, although it may be possible just to regard the detail of the piano as a sign of the bourgeois status of its owner, and that of the boxes as a sign of disorder and something like a reverse or fall in status, appropriately evocative of the Aubain household, there seems to be no such end in view to justify the reference to the barometer, an object which is neither incongruous nor significant, and which, therefore, at first sight, seems not to belong to the domain of the *notable*. In Michelet's sentence, also, it is difficult to account structurally for

all the details: the only thing that is indispensable to the account is the statement that the executioner came after the painter. How long the sitting lasted, and the size and location of the door, are useless (but the theme of the door, and death's soft knocking, have indisputable symbolic value). Even if they are not plentiful, 'useless details' thus seem inevitable: any narrative, at least any Western narrative of the ordinary sort, has some.

Insignificant *notation* (taking 'insignificant' in the strong sense – apparently detached from the semiotic structure of the narrative)⁴ – is related to description, even if the object seems to be denoted by a single word (in reality, the pure word does not exist: Flaubert's barometer is not cited as an isolated unit, it is situated, placed in a syntagm that is both referential and syntactic). This underlines the enigmatic character of any description, of which something must be said. The general structure of the narrative, at least as this has been analysed at one time or another up to the present, appears essentially *predictive*; to be extremely schematic, ignoring the numerous digressions, delays, changes of direction, or surprises which the narrative conventions add to this schema, it can be said that, at each juncture of the narrative syntagm, someone says to the hero (or to the reader, it does not matter which): if you act in this way, if you choose this alternative, then this is what will happen (the *reported* nature of these predictions does not alter their practical effect). Description is quite different: it has no predictive aspect; it is 'analogical', its structure being purely additive, and not incorporating that circuit of choices and alternatives which makes a narration look like a vast traffic control centre, provided with referential (and not merely discursive) temporality. This is an opposition which has its importance for anthropology: when, influenced by the work of von Frisch, some imagined that bees might have a language, it had to be recognized that, while these animals might have a predictive system of dances, used in food-gathering, they possess nothing resembling a *description*.⁵ Description thus appears to be a characteristic of so-called higher languages, in that, seemingly paradoxically, it is not justified by any purpose of action or communication. The singularity of the description (or of the 'useless detail') in the narrative fabric, its isolatedness, brings up a question of primary importance for the structural analysis of narrative. This question is the following: is everything in the narrative meaningful, significant? And if not, if there exist insignificant stretches, what is, so to speak, the ultimate significance of this insignificance?

It should first be recalled that Western culture, in one of its major currents, has certainly not left description without a meaning, but has in fact assigned to it an end perfectly well recognized by the institution of literature. This current is rhetoric, and the end is 'beauty': description has long had an aesthetic function. Very early in antiquity, to the two explicitly functional

genres of oratory – legal and political discourse – was added a third, epideictic discourse, the set speech whose goal was to excite the admiration of the audience (and not to persuade it); and this genre, whatever the rituals governing its use – whether praise of a hero or an obituary – contained the seeds of the notion of an aesthetic purpose in language. In Alexandrian neo-rhetoric of the second century A.D. there was an infatuation for the *ekphrasis*, a polished piece, and detachable (thus having its own purpose, independent of any general function), whose object was to describe places, times, people or works of art; and this tradition was maintained down through the Middle Ages. As Curtius⁶ has emphasized, throughout this period description was not constrained by any desire for realism; truth, or even verisimilitude, was of little moment – nobody was bothered when lions or olive trees were placed in a northern landscape. The only constraints that mattered were descriptive ones; plausibility was not referential, but overtly discursive; it was the rules of the discourse genre which laid down the law.

Moving ahead to Flaubert, we see that the aesthetic intention of description is still very strong. In *Madame Bovary*, the description of Rouen (a real referent if there ever was one) is subjected to the tyrannical constraints of what must be called aesthetic plausibility, as is attested by the corrections made in this passage in the course of six successive versions.⁷ We note first of all that the corrections are in no way due to closer attention to the model: Rouen, as perceived by Flaubert, stays the same, or more exactly, if it changes a little from one version to the next, this is only because it was necessary to tighten up an image or avoid a phonetic redundancy condemned by the rules of *le beau style*, or else to create the appropriate environment for some happy but quite contingent expressive find.⁸ Next we see that the descriptive fabric, which at first glance seems to assign great importance (by its length and attention to detail) to the object *Rouen*, is really no more than a kind of background or setting meant to receive the jewels of a few precious metaphors, the neutral matter enveloping the precious symbolic ingredients, as if, in Rouen, all that was important was the rhetorical figures available for describing what one sees, as if Rouen was only notable via its substitutions ('the masts like a forest of needles, the islands like great immobile black fish, the clouds like aerial waves silently breaking against a cliff'). Lastly, one sees that the entire description is *constructed* so as to associate Rouen with a painting: it is a painted scene taken on by language ('Thus, seen from above, the entire landscape looked as motionless as a painting'). The writer fulfils here the definition given by Plato of the artist: a maker in the third degree, since he imitates what is already the simulation of an essence.⁹ So although the description of Rouen is perfectly 'irrelevant' to the narrative structure of *Madame Bovary* (it can be attached to no functional sequence, nor to any signified (*signifié*) of characterization, atmosphere, or information), it is in no

way shocking, being justified, if not by the logic of the work, at least by the laws of literature; it has a meaning, but that meaning is given by its conformity, not to the object of description, but to the cultural rules governing representation.

Nevertheless, the aesthetic intention of Flaubertian description is totally interwoven with the imperatives of 'realism', as if exactitude of reference, superior or indifferent to all other functions, of itself commanded and justified description of the referent, or, in the case of a description reduced to a single word, its denotation. Here aesthetic constraints are impregnated – at least as an alibi – with referential constraints: it is probable that, if one had arrived at Rouen by stagecoach, the view one would have had descending the hill road which leads to the city would not have been 'objectively' different from the panorama described by Flaubert. This mixing, this interweaving of constraints, has two advantages: on the one hand the aesthetic function, by conferring a meaning on the set piece, is a safeguard against a downward spiral into endless detail. For, when discourse is no longer guided and limited by the structural imperatives of the story (functions and signals), there is nothing to tell the writer why he should stop descriptive details at one point rather than another: if it was not subject to aesthetic or rhetorical choice, any 'seeing' would be inexhaustible by discourse; there would always be some corner, some detail, some nuance of location or colour to add. On the other hand, by stating the referent to be real, and by pretending to follow it slavishly, realistic description avoids being seduced into fantasizing (a precaution which was believed necessary for the 'objectivity' of the account). Classical rhetoric had in a sense institutionalized the fantasy under the name of a particular figure, hypotyposis, whose function was to 'place things before the hearer's eyes', not in a neutral manner, merely reporting, but by giving to the scene all the radiance of desire (this was a division of vividly illumined discourse, with prismatic outlines: the *illustris oratio*). Having proclaimed its renunciation of the constraints of the rhetorical code, realism had to find a new reason to describe.

What the irreducible residues of functional analysis have in common is that they denote what is commonly called 'concrete reality' (casual movements, transitory attitudes, insignificant objects, redundant words). Unvarnished 'representation' of 'reality', a naked account of 'what is' (or was), thus looks like a resistance to meaning, a resistance which confirms the great mythical opposition between the true-to-life (the living) and the intelligible. It suffices to recall that for the ideology of our time, obsessive reference to the 'concrete' (in what is grandiloquently asked of the sciences of man, of literature, of behaviour) is always brandished as a weapon against meaning, as if there were some indisputable law that what is truly alive could not signify – and vice versa. The resistance of 'reality' (in its written form, of

course) to structure is quite limited in fictional narrative, which by definition is constructed on a model which has, on the whole, no other constraints than those of intelligibility. But this same 'reality' becomes the essential reference in historical narrative, which is supposed to report 'what really happened'. What does it matter that a detail has no function in the account as long as it denotes 'what took place'? 'Concrete reality' becomes a sufficient justification for what is said. History (historical discourse: *historia rerum gestarum*) is in fact the model for those narratives which accept, as a filling for the gaps in their functions, *notations* which are structurally superfluous. It is logical, therefore, that realism in literature should have been, give or take a few decades, contemporaneous with the reign of 'objective' history, to which should be added the present-day development of techniques, activities, and institutions based on an endless need to authenticate the 'real': photography (direct evidence of 'what was there'), reportage, exhibitions of ancient objects (the success of the Tutankhamun show is a sufficient indication), tours to monuments and historical sites. All this demonstrates that the 'real' is assumed not to need any independent justification, that it is powerful enough to negate any notion of 'function', that it can be expressed without there being any need for it to be integrated into a structure, and that the *having-been-there* of things is a sufficient reason for speaking of them.

Since antiquity, the 'real' and history have gone together (seemingly truthful), but this helped to oppose it to the 'vraisemblable' that is, to the very nature of narrative (imitation or 'poetry'). The whole of classical culture was for centuries nourished by the idea that there could be no contamination of the 'vraisemblable' by the real. At first because what is 'vraisemblable' is never other than the thinkable: it is entirely subject to (public) opinion. Nicole said: 'One must not view things as they are in themselves, nor as he who speaks or writes knows them to be, but only in relation to what the reader or the hearer knows of them.'¹⁰ Then because it was thought that what is 'vraisemblable' is general and not particular, as is history (hence the tendency, in classical texts, to functionalize every detail, to produce strong structures and, it would seem, to leave no notation which is justified only by its conformity to 'reality'). Finally because, with the 'vraisemblable', the opposite is never impossible, since description is founded on majority, but not unanimous, opinion. The motto implicitly prefacing all classical discourse (obeying the ancients' 'vraisemblance') is: *Esto* (Let there be, suppose . . .). The kind of 'real', fragmented, interstitial descriptive *notation* we are dealing with here does not appeal to this implicit introduction, and it takes its place in the structural fabric with no hint of such a hypothetical qualification. Just for that reason, there is a break between the old 'vraisemblance' and modern realism; but for that reason also, a new 'vraisemblance' is born, which is precisely what is called 'realism' (taking

this term to refer to any discourse which accepts statements whose only justification is their referent).

Semiotically, the 'concrete detail' is constituted by the *direct* collusion of a referent and a signifier; the signified is expelled from the sign, and along with it, of course, there is eliminated the possibility of developing a *form of the signified*, that is, the narrative structure itself. (Realist literature is, to be sure, narrative, but that is because its realism is only fragmentary, erratic, restricted to 'details', and because the most realistic narrative imaginable unfolds in an unrealistic manner.) This is what might be called the *referential illusion*.¹¹ The truth behind this illusion is this: eliminated from the realist utterance as a signified of denotation, the 'real' slips back in as a signified of connotation; for at the very moment when these details are supposed to denote reality directly, all that they do, tacitly, is signify it. Flaubert's barometer, Michelet's little door, say, in the last analysis, only this: *we are the real*. It is the category of the 'real', and not its various contents, which is being signified; in other words, the very absence of the signified, to the advantage of the referent, standing alone, becomes the true signifier of realism. An 'effet de réel', (a reality effect) is produced, which is the basis of that unavowed 'vraisemblance' which forms the aesthetic of all the standard works of modernity.

This new 'vraisemblance' is very different from the old, for it is neither a respect for the 'laws of the genre', nor even a disguise for them, but arises rather from an intention to alter the tripartite nature of the sign so as to make the descriptive notation a pure encounter between the object and its expression. The disintegration of the sign – which seems in fact to be the major concern of modernism – is indeed present in the realist enterprise, but in a somewhat regressive manner, since it is accomplished in the name of referential plenitude, while on the contrary the goal today is to empty the sign and to push back its object to infinity to the point of calling into question, in radical fashion, the age-old aesthetic of 'representation'.

Notes

1. G. Flaubert, *Un Coeur Simple*, in *Trois Contes* (Paris, Charpentier-Fasquelle, 1893), p. 4.
2. J. Michelet, *Histoire de France, La Révolution*, vol. v (Lausanne, Éditions Rencontre, 1967), p. 292.
3. 'Introduction à l'analyse structurale des récits', *Communications* 8 (Nov. 1966), pp. 1–27.
4. In this brief survey, we give no examples of 'insignificant' notation, since the insignificant can be illustrated only within the framework of a very large structure: when cited, a notation is neither significant nor insignificant: it requires a previously analysed context.

5. F. Bresson, 'La Signification', in *Problèmes de psycho-linguistique* (Paris, P.U.F., 1963).
6. E. R. Curtius, *La Littérature européenne et le Moyen Age latin* (Paris, P.U.F., 1956), ch. 10.
7. The six successive versions of this description are given by A. Albalat in *Le Travail du style* (Paris, A. Colin, 1903), pp. 72ff.
8. The mechanism is well noted by Valéry, in *Littérature*, when he comments on a line of Baudelaire's: 'The servant with the big heart . . .' ('This line *came* to Baudelaire . . . And Baudelaire continued. He buried the cook in a lawn, which goes against the custom, but goes with the rhyme . . .').
9. Plato, *Republic* x, 599.
10. Cited by R. Bray in *Formation de la doctrine classique* (Paris, Nizet, 1963), p. 208.
11. The illusion is clearly illustrated by the programme which Thiers established for the historian: 'To be simply true, to be as things themselves are, to be nothing more than them, to be nothing other than by them, like them, as much as them' (cited by C. Jullian, *Historiens français du XIXe siècle* (Paris, Hachette, no date), p. lxiii).